DEALS

Viatris buys Pacira for $1.65B to build a non-opioid pain franchise

Viatris agreed on October 8 to acquire Pacira BioSciences for $1.65 billion, a $36.50-per-share all-cash tender offer. Pacira's draw is its non-opioid pain portfolio led by Exparel, plus the newer Zilretto, giving Viatris a commercial pain franchise rather than a science project. The timing fits a wider push to build out non-opioid options as prescribers and payers keep moving away from opioids.

- **Target:** Pacira BioSciences (public, non-opioid pain)
- **Structure:** $1.65B, $36.50/share all-cash tender offer
- **Lead assets:** Exparel and Zilretto
- **Advisors:** Viatris — Morgan Stanley. Pacira — Goldman Sachs.

Galderma takes ZO Skin Health for $1.5B

Galderma agreed on October 14 to buy ZO Skin Health for $1.5 billion in enterprise value. ZO is a physician-dispensed skincare brand, and the deal pushes Galderma deeper into the professional aesthetics and dermatology market it already leads. It's a consumer-adjacent play more than a pipeline bet, which is becoming a theme in the derm space.

- **Target:** ZO Skin Health (private, physician-dispensed skincare)
- **Structure:** $1.5B enterprise value
- **Advisors:** Galderma — Lazard and J.P. Morgan. Sellers (ZO Skin Health and Blackstone) — Raymond James and Citi.

Ferring buys fertility startup Gameto for up to $1.38B

Ferring Pharmaceuticals agreed on October 27 to acquire Gameto for up to $1.3825 billion. Gameto's technology, Fertilo, matures eggs outside the body using engineered ovarian support cells, aiming to make IVF cycles less drug-intensive. For Ferring, already a leader in reproductive medicine, it's a bet on reshaping how IVF is done rather than just adding another product.

- **Target:** Gameto (private, fertility / reproductive health)
- **Structure:** Up to $1.3825B
- **Lead technology:** Fertilo, in vitro egg maturation
- **Advisors:** not disclosed.

Merck KGaA buys Silence Therapeutics for $1.1B

Germany's Merck KGaA agreed on October 19 to acquire Silence Therapeutics for $1.1 billion in cash, roughly $1.3 billion in equity value. The prize is divesiran, an siRNA for polycythemia vera, a rare blood cancer where the marrow overproduces red blood cells. Divesiran posted an 88% response rate versus 19% for placebo in Phase 2 and is headed for a Phase 3 start in the first half of 2027. It gives Merck KGaA a late-stage RNA asset in hematology.

- **Target:** Silence Therapeutics (public, RNAi)
- **Structure:** $1.1B cash (~$1.3B equity value)

- **Lead asset:** Divesiran, siRNA for polycythemia vera (Phase 3-ready)
- **Advisors:** Silence Therapeutics — Morgan Stanley and Centerview Partners. Merck KGaA financial advisor not disclosed.

Under The Radar

Alcon agreed on October 20 to buy Neurotech Pharmaceuticals for $550 million plus undisclosed contingent payments, adding an eye-disease cell therapy to its portfolio. Smaller than the headline deals, but another sign that strategics are paying up for platforms outside their usual lane.

Deep Dive: Reading Between The Lines

The pattern:

October's M&A skewed toward commercial and consumer-facing assets, not early pipelines. Viatris bought a marketed pain franchise. Galderma bought a skincare brand. Ferring bought a way to change how a procedure is done. Even the Silence deal, the most science-driven of the group, was for an asset with Phase 2 data already in hand. Buyers are paying for things that are close to or already generating revenue, not for shots on goal.

Why it matters:

When the deals clustering at the $1 to $2 billion mark are all about franchises and platforms rather than binary readouts, it says acquirers want predictability. That's consistent with a market still cautious on risk, and it leaves earlier-stage companies leaning on licensing deals and IPOs for capital instead of buyouts.

Through the end of October, 2026 has logged 76 disclosed deals worth roughly $207.8 billion, split 29 public to 47 private.

IPOs

Lycia leads the window with an upsized $318M debut, up 67%

Lycia Therapeutics priced an upsized IPO at $18, the top of its range, on October 26, raising about $317.5 million, and the stock surged roughly 67% on its first day. Lycia is a targeted protein degradation company built on its LYTAC platform, which tags disease-causing proteins for removal through the cell's own clearance machinery. Backed by HBM and RTW, it was the standout biotech IPO of the month and a sign that investors will still pay up for a differentiated platform.

- **Priced:** $18/share (top of range), October 26
- **Raised:** ~$317.5M (upsized)
- **Debut:** up ~67%
- **Platform:** LYTAC targeted protein degradation

Bambusa and Aspen round out a busy end of the month

Two more biotechs debuted October 30. Bambusa Therapeutics, an immunology and inflammation company founded by former BioNTech leaders, raised about $168.9 million for its lead atopic dermatitis program, but the stock slipped around 7% on its first day. Aspen Neuroscience, a Parkinson's cell therapy developer working on sasineprocel, raised about $141 million. The mixed receptions, one hot IPO and two softer ones, track the selectivity that has defined the public market all year.

- **Bambusa Therapeutics:** ~$168.9M, immunology/inflammation, down ~7% on debut
- **Aspen Neuroscience:** ~$141M, Parkinson's cell therapy (sasineprocel)

That brings 2026 to roughly 29 biotech IPOs raising about $8 billion. Capital is still flowing to new issuers, but the market is clearly rewarding some and punishing others on day one.

LICENSING DEALS

Roche Signs Up to $15B ADC Collaboration With Hansoh Pharma

On Monday (10/19), Hansoh Pharma announced a collaboration and license agreement with Roche covering a broad portfolio of antibody-drug conjugate (ADC) programs, the largest licensing deal of the month and one of the largest China-sourced deals of 2026.

- **Scope:** The deal spans two Hansoh preclinical ADC programs plus multiple programs against targets proposed by Roche, all built on Hansoh's ADC platform. Hansoh leads early development through global Phase 1a trials, after which Roche takes over development and commercialization everywhere outside mainland China, Hong Kong, Macau and Taiwan, where Hansoh keeps its rights.
- **Deal terms:** $400 million upfront and a further $110 million payment at the first anniversary, plus more than $15 billion in development, regulatory and commercial milestones and tiered royalties. Hansoh also holds an option to co-develop up to two programs outside its home territories.
- **Why it matters:** This is the second ADC pact between the two companies, coming almost exactly one year after Roche paid $80 million upfront for ex-China rights to Hansoh's CDH17-directed ADC HS-20110 in a deal worth up to $1.45 billion. Endpoints News counts it as Roche's sixth China deal since August, and it fits a clear pattern of a large pharma with patent cliffs ahead using Chinese platforms to refill its oncology pipeline. Only about 3% of the headline value is committed upfront, so the real test is which programs reach the clinic.
- **Advisors:** not disclosed.

Novartis Licenses Abogen's mRNA-Encoded T-Cell Engager for $575M Upfront, Up to $7.8B Total

On Friday (10/2), Abogen Biosciences announced a licensing and option agreement giving Novartis exclusive worldwide rights to ABO2203, its lead RNA asset, for autoimmune disease.

- **Mechanism:** ABO2203 is a lipid nanoparticle formulated mRNA that encodes a CD19xCD3 T-cell engager. After injection, the patient's own cells produce the engager in vivo, with the goal of depleting the B cells that drive autoimmune disease, without making a recombinant protein in a factory.
- **Pipeline stage:** Abogen calls it the first mRNA-encoded T-cell engager to enter clinical evaluation for autoimmune disease. A Phase 1 autoimmune trial began at Ruijin Hospital in 2024, and the asset has also been tested in B-cell non-Hodgkin lymphoma, which supplied extra pharmacokinetic and safety data.
- **Deal terms:** $575 million upfront, plus up to roughly $7.2 billion in development, regulatory and commercial milestones if Novartis exercises all options, plus royalties. Novartis also holds exclusive options on additional programs from Abogen's RNA platform, and the number of programs and their targets were not disclosed.
- **Why it matters:** The deal arrived weeks after Novartis paused its own autoimmune CAR-T program (rapcabtagene autoleucel) following three deaths, and it shows the immune reset thesis shifting toward in vivo approaches. The evidence base is still thin, with small early datasets, so most of the $7.8 billion headline depends on future options and milestones.
- **Advisors:** not disclosed.

PHASE TRIALS AND CLINICAL DATA

Merck and Moderna: Intismeran Plus Keytruda Cuts Melanoma Recurrence Risk by 42% in INTerpath-001

Detailed Phase 3 results were released on Thursday (10/22) and presented on Saturday (10/24) in Presidential Symposium I at ESMO 2026, with simultaneous acceptance for publication in The New England Journal of Medicine. The companies had announced topline success on August 19, and this was the first full look at the data. INTerpath-001 is the first Phase 3 win for an individualized neoantigen therapy and for an mRNA-based cancer therapy.

- **Trial design:** A randomized, double blind Phase 3 trial of 1,137 patients with completely resected stage IIB to IV melanoma, assigned 2:1 to intismeran (1 mg every three weeks, up to nine doses) plus Keytruda or placebo plus

Keytruda for about one year. Each dose is built from the patient's own tumor and encodes up to 34 neoantigens. The primary endpoint was recurrence-free survival (RFS).

- **Results:** After a median follow-up of 24.6 months, the combination reduced the risk of recurrence or death by 42% (HR 0.58, 95% CI 0.45 to 0.75, p<0.001). Two-year RFS was 82.2% versus 70.0%, and the risk of distant metastasis or death fell by 38% (HR 0.62, p=0.002). Overall survival is not yet mature but trends favorably. Grade 3 to 5 treatment-related adverse events were similar between arms (14.2% vs 13.4%), with no new safety signals.
- **Why it matters:** The benefit was concentrated after the six month immunization period. Over the first six months the combination looked like Keytruda alone (HR 0.99), but after six months it cut recurrence risk by 58% (HR 0.42) in a prespecified sensitivity analysis. Merck says it is engaging regulators, and the program includes nine Phase 2 and 3 trials, including three Phase 3 studies in lung cancer.

Roche: Divarasib Beats Sotorasib and Adagrasib Head to Head in KRAS G12C Lung Cancer (Krascendo 1)

On Sunday (10/25), Roche and Genentech presented full Phase 3 Krascendo 1 results at ESMO 2026 in the Presidential Symposium, with simultaneous publication in The New England Journal of Medicine. Roche had reported a topline win in July, but the survival numbers were first disclosed this month. The study is the only global head to head trial of a next-generation KRAS G12C inhibitor against the approved first-generation drugs.

- **Trial design:** A randomized, open label Phase 3 trial of 338 patients with previously treated, locally advanced or metastatic KRAS G12C-mutated NSCLC, assigned to divarasib once daily (n=167) or to the investigator's choice of sotorasib once daily or adagrasib twice daily (n=171). The primary endpoint was blinded independent central review PFS.
- **Results:** After a median follow-up of 14.3 months, divarasib reduced the risk of progression or death by 42%, with median PFS of 9.8 versus 5.7 months and 44% of patients progression-free at one year versus 24%. Median overall survival was 17.7 versus 12.0 months (HR 0.56, 95% CI 0.41 to 0.78, p<0.001), a 44% reduction in the risk of death. Confirmed response rate was about 58% versus 32%, and median duration of response was 11.9 versus 6.9 months.
- **Why it matters:** Winning on overall survival against an active control, not placebo, is a high bar and makes divarasib a likely new standard in the second line setting. One caveat is that the control arm was weighted heavily toward sotorasib, so conclusions about divarasib versus adagrasib specifically are limited.

MACRO

ESMO defined the month on the science side. Two Presidential Symposium readouts, intismeran with Keytruda in melanoma and divarasib in KRAS G12C lung cancer, both landed as practice-shaping wins, and both point to where oncology is heading: individualized mRNA vaccines and next-generation targeted drugs that beat the incumbents head to head. On the deal side, the money kept moving toward things buyers can underwrite, marketed franchises, late-stage assets, and proven platforms, while early-stage companies turned to licensing and a still-open IPO window for capital. Roche's latest China ADC pact was a reminder that large pharma is increasingly filling its pipeline from Chinese platforms. The overall picture is a market that is active but discriminating, paying up for data and revenue and staying cautious on everything else.

SOURCES

All figures are drawn from company press releases, SEC filings, FDA announcements, and the BioBucks deal trackers, cross-checked against primary and wire reporting. The licensing and clinical sources below are provided as cited in the original drafts.

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